

Land Your First Trade Apprenticeship

The Step-by-Step Playbook (2026)

The complete playbook for landing a paid trade apprenticeship — from your first application to your first day on the job. Built for 17-25 year-olds ready to earn \$40K-\$100K+ instead of borrowing \$100K+.

5-Step

App. System

750K+

Open Positions

\$0

Tuition (Union)

Why Apprenticeships Beat College

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THE DEBT-FREE CAREER PATH

Young adults take on \$80K-\$160K in student debt for degrees that may not pay off. The trades have 750,000+ open positions — HVAC alone has 36,700 — and employers are desperate for young workers — willing to pay to train you.

APPRENTICESHIPS vs. COLLEGE

- Pay YOU from day one. College charges \$10K-\$40K/year.
- Journey-level credential in 3-5 years vs. 4+ for a bachelor's.
- Zero student debt (avg grad: \$30K-\$40K in loans).
- On-the-job training > classroom theory for trade employers.
- Journey-level pay (\$45K-\$100K+) matches many degrees.
- Union apprenticeships: \$0 tuition, employer + union fund training.

WHO THIS IS FOR

- 17-25 year olds deciding after high school.
- Anyone who wants to earn while learning.
- People who've heard trades pay well but don't know where to start.

WHAT YOU'LL LEARN

- 5-step system: research → prep → kit → test → interview.
- Certifications before you apply (OSHA 10, driver's license).
- Resume + cover letter templates (union & non-union).
- Union vs. non-union comparison.
- Apprentice pay by year for 6 trades.
- 8 interview Q&As + follow-up email.
- 10 common mistakes that kill applications.

Step 1-2: Research & Background Prep

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STEP 1: RESEARCH & DECIDE

Spend 1-2 weeks researching. Rushing = wrong program.

- Take the TradeLift quiz to narrow top 2 trades.
- Compare union vs non-union routes.
- Call 3 contractors: "Do you take apprentices?"
- Check apprenticeship.gov for registered programs.

STEP 2: BACKGROUND PREPARATION

Get these done before applying:

Driver's License

Required for most positions. Clean record = asset.

OSHA 10-Hour

Universal entry credential. Online, \$25-\$40. Get this FIRST.

Physical Fitness

Trades are physical. Be ready for 50+ lbs, all weather.

TOOLS TO BRING

Tape measure (25 ft)	\$10-\$25
Utility knife + blades	\$5-\$10
Safety glasses (Z87.1)	\$5-\$15
Work gloves (cut-resistant)	\$15-\$35
Hard hat (if not provided)	\$15-\$30
Steel-toe boots (ASTM)	\$80-\$160

Step 3: Application Kit

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TRADE RESUME (COPY-PASTE)

One page. Certifications + reliability > extracurriculars.

[YOUR NAME] · [City, State] · [Phone] · [Email]

OBJECTIVE

Motivated worker seeking [TRADE] apprenticeship. OSHA 10 certified.

CERTIFICATIONS

- OSHA 10-Hour — [Date]
- First Aid/CPR — [Date]

EXPERIENCE

[Job/project] · [Dates] — hands-on tasks, reliability.

EDUCATION

[HS/GED] — [Year]

REFERENCES — Available upon request.

COVER LETTER TEMPLATES

UNION

Dear [Training Director], I express interest in the [Trade] apprenticeship with [Local #]. I hold OSHA 10, am physically capable, and committed to a long-term career. I welcome the chance to discuss the next intake window.

NON-UNION

Dear [Hiring Manager], I apply for an apprenticeship/helper position with [Company]. I hold OSHA 10, have reliable transport, and own basic tools. I'm ready to work hard and learn.

Step 4: The Aptitude Test

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WHAT'S ON THE TEST

Most union programs require an aptitude test. Pass/fail — qualifying score, not perfect.

1. Math (Algebra & Arithmetic)

Fractions, percentages, ratios, word problems. IBEW weights heaviest.

2. Reading Comprehension

Passages + questions. Read trade articles for vocab.

3. Mechanical Comprehension

Levers, pulleys, gears. Not on every test — check yours.

4-6 WEEKS BEFORE: STUDY PLAN

- Khan Academy (free): algebra, ratios, percentages.
- Union prep books: IBEW/UA aptitude guides.
- Timed practice 2-3x/week under real conditions.
- Sample questions at [apprenticeship.gov](https://www.apprenticeship.gov).

TEST-DAY TIPS

- Practice: timed, no phone, quiet room.
- Skip >90s questions — come back later.
- Eliminate obvious wrongs first.
- 70-80% usually passes. Don't aim for perfect.

Step 5: The Interview

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8 QUESTIONS + ANSWERS TO REHEARSE

Q1: Why [trade]?

"I like hands-on problem-solving. I want a skill always in demand."

Q2: What do you know?

Reference BLS growth, local demand, or a project. Show research.

Q3: Physical work?

"Ready to lift, carry, and work in all weather."

Q4: Commit to 3-5 years?

"Yes. This is a long-term investment."

Q5: Transportation?

"Yes. Driver's license + [vehicle/transport]."

Q6: Team experience?

Sports, school projects, volunteer work, or past jobs.

Q7: Why pick you?

"Punctual, don't quit, here because I want this career."

Q8: Questions for us?

"Typical first year?" / "Tools to bring day one?"

Follow-Up & Union vs. Non-Union

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FOLLOW-UP EMAIL (WITHIN 24 HOURS)

Copy, paste, customize. Separates you from 90% of applicants.

Subject: Thank you — [Trade] Interview

Dear [Interviewer],

Thank you for meeting about the [Trade] apprenticeship.
I enjoyed [detail]. I'm excited and confident I can contribute.
Let me know if you need anything.

Best, [Name] · [Phone] · [Email]

UNION vs. NON-UNION

Factor	Union	Non-Union
Pay	Published scale	Varies, negotiable
Training	Standardized	Varies by company
Tuition	\$0 funded	\$5K-\$15K OOP
Benefits	Health+pension	Varies/none
Placement	Contractor network	Self-market
Mobility	Portable license	May re-cert
Raises	Guaranteed steps	Performance-based

Bottom line: union = structure + \$0 tuition. Non-union = flexibility + faster hiring. Apply to both.

Apprentice Pay by Year

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WHAT YOU'LL EARN

Every registered apprenticeship pays from day one. 40-50% of journeyman scale, raises yearly. Source: tradelift.surge.sh/blog/apprentice-wages-by-year.html

Trade	Yr 1	Yr 2	Yr 3-4	Journeyman
Electrician	\$15-\$22	\$16-\$25	\$17-\$32	\$60K-\$80K+
Plumber	\$16-\$22	\$17-\$25	\$19-\$32	\$56K-\$74K
HVAC Tech	\$15-\$20	\$17-\$23	\$20-\$28	\$50K-\$70K
Welder	\$16-\$20	\$18-\$24	\$20-\$28	\$45K-\$70K
Carpenter	\$15-\$19	\$16-\$22	\$18-\$26	\$45K-\$65K
Elevator Inst.	\$20-\$25	\$24-\$29	\$29-\$38	\$80K-\$100K+

BLS medians: electrician \$61,590; plumber/pipefitter \$59,880; HVAC \$57,310; carpenter \$51,390; welder ~\$47K; construction mgr \$101,900.

ALL 12 TRADES: JOURNEY-LEVEL BANDS

Site figures from trades.html + quiz.js. Six trades are marked “assumed — no dedicated post yet” because no dedicated salary post exists for them on the site.

Electrician	\$60K-\$80K	blog-cited (BLS median on site)
Plumber	\$55K-\$75K	blog-cited (BLS median on site)
Welder	\$45K-\$70K	blog-cited (BLS median on site)
HVAC	\$50K-\$70K	blog-cited (BLS median on site)
Carpenter	\$45K-\$65K	blog-cited (BLS median on site)
Mason	\$45K-\$70K	assumed — no dedicated post yet
Roofer	\$40K-\$65K	assumed — no dedicated post yet
Pipefitter	\$60K-\$85K	blog-cited (BLS median on site)
Ironworker	\$55K-\$80K	assumed — no dedicated post yet
Diesel Mech	\$45K-\$65K	assumed — no dedicated post yet
Auto Mech	\$40K-\$65K	assumed — no dedicated post yet
Constr. Mgr	\$70K-\$100K	assumed — no dedicated post yet

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Year 1: \$15-\$25/hr by trade and union status.
- Biggest raises in years 3-4 (toward 80-90% of journeyman).
- Licensing jump = largest raise of your career.
- Union = \$0 tuition vs. \$30K-\$40K college debt.
- Overtime + certs add \$4K-\$5.5K+/year.

FIRST-MONTH CHECKLIST

You got in. Don't blow it. First 30 days set the tone.

WEEK 1: SHOW UP & OBSERVE

- Arrive 15 min early daily.
- Introduce yourself to every crew member.
- Bring own tools, PPE, water, lunch.
- Don't touch anyone's tools without asking.
- Listen more than talk. Write everything down.

WEEK 2: START LEARNING

- Ask how before attempting each task.
- Learn the JSA (Job Safety Analysis).
- Volunteer for dirty work = trust builder.
- Keep your workspace clean.

WEEKS 3-4: EARN TRUST

- Take on small tasks independently.
- Ask: "What can I do better?"
- Clock in/out exactly.
- Stay off your phone on site.

10 Common Mistakes

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10 MISTAKES THAT GET YOU REJECTED

From hiring managers and union training directors.

1. Showing up late.

Punctuality = #1. Late twice = gone.

2. No OSHA 10.

No card = no interview in many shops.

3. One application only.

Apply to 5+. Different windows, different odds.

4. No follow-up call.

Call 5-7 days later. Most never do.

5. Lying about experience.

Tradespeople talk. Be honest.

6. No tools at interview.

Tape + glasses at minimum.

7. No thank-you email.

5 min. Separates you from 90%.

8. No company research.

Know their trades and job sites.

9. Unprepared for aptitude test.

4-6 weeks of study is enough.

10. Quitting year one.

First year = hardest. Stay = succeed.

Resources & Links

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RESOURCES

TRAINING

[apprenticeship.gov](#)

Federal apprenticeship finder

[NCCER.org](#)

Industry credentials, 14+ trades

[SkillsUSA.org](#)

Career-tech competitions

CERTS

[OSHA.gov](#)

10-Hour and 30-Hour online

[EPA 608](#)

Required for HVAC

[AWS](#)

Welding certifications

SALARY DATA

[bls.gov/ooh](#)

Official salary + growth data

[tradelift.surge.sh/blog/apprentice-wages-by-year.html](#)

Year-by-year apprentice pay

[tradelift.surge.sh/getting-started.html](#)

5-step career roadmap

UNIONS

[IBEW.org](#)

Electrical workers

[UA.org](#)

Plumbers & Pipefitters

[UBC.org](#)

Carpenters & Joiners

What To Do Next

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TAKE THE FREE QUIZ

Not sure which trade fits? The free 2-minute quiz matches you.

Take the Free Quiz

tradelift.surge.sh/quiz.html

MORE FREE RESOURCES

- 12 free career roadmaps: tradelift.surge.sh
- Trade Career Fit Guide (free): tradelift.surge.sh/careers.guide
- Tools guide: tradelift.surge.sh/tools.html
- Getting started: tradelift.surge.sh/getting-started.html

DISCLAIMER

Salary data from tradelift.surge.sh (BLS + industry). Earnings vary by location, experience, certifications. Educational only; no employment guarantee. TradeLift © 2026.

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A TradeLift Premium Guide

tradelift.surge.sh

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Built for the next generation of skilled tradespeople.

You Have the Plan. Now Execute.

Every step here is something you can do this week. Don't wait. Start with the quiz, get OSHA, make the calls.
The trades are hiring.

tradelift.surge.sh/quiz.html

Questions? Reply to any TradeLift email. We'll make it right.